

General Playtest Overview

Missions completed: 1 - 12

Total playtime: 9 hours 52 minutes and 40 seconds

Total attempts: 391

Overall result: All twelve missions completed

Bugs identified: None

Difficulty Progression

The **overall difficulty progression across the twelve missions felt inconsistent**, with several noticeable spikes and drops.

EASY

- **Mission 1:** Quite difficult.
- **Mission 2:** Significantly easier.

MEDIUM

- **Mission 3:** Felt the most balanced.
- **Mission 4:** Another drop in difficulty.

HARD

- **Mission 5:** Major difficulty spike.
- **Mission 6:** Intentionally very easy.

VERY HARD

- **Mission 7:** Difficult again, similar to Mission 5 but slightly less frustrating.
- **Mission 8:** Fun and well designed, leaning slightly towards the easier side.

ULTRA HARD

- **Mission 9:** Also fun and well designed, with a smooth transition in difficulty, leaning slightly towards the easier side.
- **Mission 10:** Enjoyable and well balanced.

ULTRA BRUTAL

- **Mission 11:** By far the biggest difficulty spike; extremely difficult and almost near impossible without relying heavily on specific strategies and upgrades.
- **Mission 12:** Felt just right for this point in the game, although slightly long.

Overall, the main issue is the **inconsistent difficulty curve**, particularly the large spikes in Missions 5, 7 and especially 11. The later missions generally felt more enjoyable when the difficulty was challenging without becoming frustrating.

Recurring Feedback

The **larger enemy missiles**, particularly during boss encounters, were a recurring source of difficulty. I'd estimate that **around half of my deaths to them happened without me even noticing a missile had been launched**, even when I was actively expecting them. They can blend into the other visual effects, so I think a stronger visual indicator could make them easier to recognise and react to.

Upgrades and Abilities

I found myself using **Phaser quite frequently** throughout the playthrough. I noticed that the ability has an **800k bounty**, but I didn't fully understand how the weapon upgrades and bounty system were intended to work. Since I mainly avoided using ship and weapon upgrades to keep the mission difficulty comparisons consistent.

I noticed that each ship has its own bounty-based ability, but I feel these abilities could work better as **base abilities attached to each ship independently of the bounty system**. This would make each ship feel more distinct while allowing the bounty system to focus on other upgrades.

I also didn't find myself using the **camo health/speed adjustments** very often, as I didn't notice a particularly strong reason to switch between them during my playthrough.

Mission 1 – Playtest Feedback

Total attempts: 12

Result: Completed

Bugs Identified: None

Videos:

- 5-minute sample: <https://youtu.be/8jRE6hJS6WA>
 - 5-minute sample, edge: <https://youtu.be/5amU5cbb5oY>
 - Star Talon – Mission 1 Full Playthrough | 12 Attempts: <https://youtu.be/YAQ6fnUP68E>
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Boss Difficulty

I found the first boss quite difficult, requiring 12 attempts to complete. While some difficulty can be enjoyable, I think the main issue is the **lack of visual feedback indicating the threat of the larger missiles**.

The player's missiles and enemy projectiles look quite similar, and with the many bright visual effects, the larger missiles can blend in and become extremely difficult to react to or dodge. A stronger visual indicator, such as a distinct red colour, glow, marker or overlay, could communicate their threat without necessarily reducing the difficulty.

I also think making the first boss this challenging could potentially frustrate new players and discourage them from continuing. I don't consider myself an inexperienced gamer, but I still found it difficult to consistently identify the incoming missiles.

There is also **very little feedback regarding the missiles' health**. It was often difficult to tell whether I had actually hit them, and the hitbox sometimes felt unclear.

Overall, I enjoyed the level, but clearer visual feedback could make the difficulty feel more fair, balanced and readable.

Mission 2 – Playtest Feedback

Total attempts: 1

Result: Completed

Bugs Identified: None

Video:

- Star Talon – Mission 2 Full Playthrough | 1 Attempt: https://youtu.be/-On_WrmFNyI
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Progression & Mission Difficulty

Mission 2 felt **significantly easier than Mission 1**, as I completed it on my first attempt. The boss also felt very similar to the previous one but seemed to have noticeably less health (4000 vs 2000), making the encounter much easier overall. In fact, I found Mission 2 easier than the introductory mission. This may be worth reviewing if the intention is for the difficulty to gradually increase between missions.

Mission 3 – Playtest Feedback

Total attempts: 10

Result: Completed

Bugs Identified: None

Video:

- Star Talon – Mission 3 Full Playthrough | 10 Attempts: <https://youtu.be/jBZkNd-MwhI>
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Progression & Mission Difficulty

Mission 3 felt like the **most balanced difficulty** so far. It wasn't too difficult or too easy, and the progression from Mission 2 into Mission 3 felt smooth and natural. No major issues identified with difficulty or progression.

Mission 4 – Playtest Feedback

Total attempts: 2

Result: Completed

Bugs Identified: None

Video:

- Star Talon – Mission 4 Full Playthrough | 2 Attempts: https://youtu.be/YyM03USeM_g
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Progression & Mission Difficulty

Mission 4 felt **too easy compared to Mission 3**. After the more balanced difficulty of Mission 3, the difficulty seemed to drop again, making this mission feel less challenging than expected. The mission also felt **quite short**, so adding a little more length or another challenging section could help make the level feel more substantial. If the intention is for the difficulty to progressively increase between missions, Mission 4 may need some adjustment.

Mission 5 – Playtest Feedback

Total attempts: 29

Result: Completed

Bugs Identified: None

Video:

- Star Talon – Mission 5 Full Playthrough | 29 Attempts: <https://youtu.be/JmNB7kRxqxl>
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Progression & Mission Difficulty

The jump from Mission 4 to Mission 5 felt **quite significant**. While I expected the difficulty to increase, I found Mission 5 **unnecessarily difficult**, especially compared to the much easier Mission 4. The mission is also noticeably longer, which makes the contrast in difficulty even more apparent.

On the other hand, I found the boss manageable and fitting for the mission. The laser attack also felt fine and didn't cause the same frustration as the turrets.

Turret Difficulty

The **top missile turrets** were particularly frustrating. They are difficult to destroy, and whether your weapon targets the turret you want to clear can feel somewhat luck-based. Eventually, I developed a dynamic where the trade-off was actually better to **bump into the turrets and take the damage rather than spend time trying to destroy them**. However, because you can't simply ignore the turrets in the middle section without eventually being killed, I think it may be better to reduce the number of turrets or add more strategically placed health pickups to encourage this risk/reward dynamic.

I also found the **top turret during the boss section** particularly frustrating. It felt almost impossible to destroy, making it feel somewhat futile to engage with and adding unnecessary frustration to the encounter.

Environment & Collision

There was also a **small red collision** object in the top-left area of the boss section that I repeatedly collided with while trying to dodge missiles. This made the boss section even more frustrating on the attempts where I reached it, as I was already trying to manage the missiles and other hazards. **Removing it out of the boss encounter may help reduce unnecessary frustration.**

Mission 6 – Playtest Feedback

Total attempts: 4

Result: Completed

Bugs Identified: None

Video:

- Star Talon – Mission 6 Full Playthrough | 4 Attempts: <https://youtu.be/Br953tFbjpc>
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Progression & Mission Difficulty

Mission 6 felt very similar to Mission 4 in terms of difficulty. The jump from Mission 5 to Mission 6 felt quite odd, as Mission 5 was extremely difficult due to its middle section, while **Mission 6 felt comparatively too easy**. There is a lot happening on screen, but the projectiles are generally slower and therefore relatively easy to dodge and navigate through.

I found the boss balanced and fitting for the mission, with no major issues. However, I think the level could benefit from being **slightly longer** or **somewhat more difficult** to better match the progression. I would not recommend reducing the amount of health packs, as I found them useful and definitely needed during the level.

Environment & Collision

I also found it difficult to tell which environmental objects I could collide with, particularly with the curved up-and-down sections of the level. The darker buildings didn't initially feel like collision objects, which made them somewhat confusing to navigate around. After multiple playthroughs, I became more familiar with them, but **clearer visual communication of which objects are solid or hazardous** could most likely help.

Mission 7 – Playtest Feedback

Total attempts: 30

Result: Completed

Bugs Identified: None

Video:

- Star Talon – Mission 7 Full Playthrough | 30 Attempts: <https://youtu.be/V4PhhoPUjlc>
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Progression & Mission Difficulty

Mission 7 felt quite similar to Mission 5, particularly because of the number of turrets. However, it felt somewhat easier this time because I already knew how to approach and destroy the turrets and had developed a strategy for dealing with them.

I also tested the **standing-still/shooting upgrades**, which added a few extra attempts to the playthrough. Overall, the level can still feel somewhat frustrating at times, but knowing the mechanics made it more manageable.

Level Design

At **1:22**, there are two possible paths. Since the intended route is the lower path, I would recommend closing off the alternative route or connecting it back to the main path and adding something hidden or optional to make exploring it worthwhile. I explored it during the playthrough to see whether there was anything hidden.

Mission 8 – Playtest Feedback

Total attempts: 11

Result: Completed

Bugs Identified: None

Video:

- Star Talon – Mission 8 Full Playthrough | 11 Attempts: https://youtu.be/lUns8u1z_dM
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Progression & Mission Difficulty

Mission 8 was actually very fun. The level design caught me off guard at the beginning because I didn't immediately know what to expect, which made the start feel engaging. It was definitely a little more difficult than some of the earlier missions, but I wouldn't say it was harder than Mission 7.

Compared to Missions 5 and 7, where having top and bottom turrets in a confined space can make the level extremely difficult, Mission 8 felt much more balanced. It reminded me of Mission 6, but with a slight increase in difficulty. Overall, I really enjoyed it and found it **well-balanced, if anything leaning slightly towards the easier side.**

Mission 9 – Playtest Feedback

Total attempts: 6

Result: Completed

Bugs Identified: None

Video:

- Star Talon – Mission 9 Full Playthrough | 6 Attempts: <https://youtu.be/T9Pa-vKI8bY>
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Progression & Mission Difficulty

Mission 9 felt very similar to Mission 8, which made it equally enjoyable. The multiple paths and slight increase in difficulty worked well, and the transition from Mission 8 to 9 felt smooth.

However, since the level is structured quite similarly to Mission 8, it was relatively easy to progress through, taking me a total of 6 attempts. I would consider **increasing the difficulty slightly** to give the mission a bit more of its own challenge.

Mission 10 – Playtest Feedback

Total attempts: 4

Result: Completed

Bugs Identified: None

Video:

- Star Talon – Mission 10 Full Playthrough | 4 Attempts: <https://youtu.be/CJMW8q7K1nw>
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Progression & Mission Difficulty

Mission 10 introduces several new elements, particularly the **moving level design and objects**, which made the mission more challenging and engaging. The level also felt noticeably longer than previous missions, adding to the difficulty.

I found the mission **well balanced**, with the new mechanics providing a good challenge without feeling unfair. The **length is worth considering** if the bosses are intended to become increasingly difficult after the planned changes, as repeatedly replaying such a long mission after dying to a boss could potentially become frustrating. Fortunately, I could defeat it within the first attempt.

Audio

The **shots from the first two enemies are way too loud** at the beginning of the mission. Their volume should be reduced.

Mission 11 – Playtest Feedback

Total attempts: 255

Result: Completed

Bugs Identified: None

Video:

- Star Talon – Mission 11 Part 1 Playthrough | 255 Attempts:
<https://youtu.be/v1wnDcwGzlc>
 - Star Talon – Mission 11 Part 2 Playthrough | 255 Attempts:
<https://youtu.be/8L9KealjMw>
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Progression & Mission Difficulty

Mission 11 was **extremely difficult** compared to Mission 10. The progression between the two missions felt **abysmal**, with a very sudden and significant increase in difficulty. Interestingly, the **boss was probably the easiest part of the entire level**.

The mission is technically doable, but it was **really, really hard** requiring approximately **4 hours and 30 minutes** to complete. The difficulty reminded me of older games where progression often required the player to **memorize enemy patterns and level layouts** in order to move forward.

Without **memorizing patterns, pre-doing sections, ignoring large parts of the level, and having the right weapon upgrades**, this mission feels **almost unfeasible**.

Weapon & Ship Upgrades

Halfway through the level, I realized the second half **wasn't going to be realistically doable without upgrades**. I needed at least **Phaser + Chemical Superlaser** to get through the second half of the level. This makes the mission feel heavily dependent on having the right upgrades rather than simply relying on the player's skill with the base equipment.

Level Design

For the first half, I developed what I called the **"Ignore the Level" technique**. Interacting with the level felt **punished and unnecessary**, as it was often more effective to simply avoid enemies and focus on getting through the section.

This included:

- Shooting turrets **before they appeared on screen**.
- Staying at the **edge of the screen** to avoid lasers.
- Ignoring enemies whenever possible.
- Using the **health-pack locations** to plan around damage.

There is also a **power-up in the middle of the level that is very difficult to collect** because it passes through walls. It fell victim to my **"Ignore the Level" technique**, as it wasn't worth going out of my way to collect. I recommend placing it **in the same corridor the player is forced to go through**.

Moreover, the missile section had approximately **7 missile turrets + 3 missile ships**, which felt **overboard**. I had to **pre-shoot at least two turrets before even reaching the section**; otherwise, it felt practically undoable. The **mine section immediately after was also way too long**, making the ending feel unnecessarily drawn out.

Mission 12 – Playtest Feedback

Total attempts: 37

Result: Completed

Bugs Identified: None

Video:

- Star Talon – Mission 12 Full Playthrough | 37 Attempts: <https://youtu.be/l1HKu7g9tmk>
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Progression & Mission Difficulty

Mission 12 felt **appropriately balanced for its position in the game**, without being too easy or too difficult. The boss having **4,000 HP** felt fitting for the level, and I think the Belly Blast and Phaser mechanics worked well with the mission.

The level can feel somewhat slow and lengthy at times, which became a little tedious during the playthrough, but I think this also contributes to the overall difficulty.

One possible adjustment could be **switching Missions 11 and 12** to make the overall progression feel more natural. If doing so, reducing or removing the minefield + several turrets in Mission 12 and increasing the boss to around **4,000 HP** could help maintain an appropriate level of difficulty.

Enemy Design

The **rotating ships with lasers** were somewhat unclear in terms of their damage. I couldn't consistently tell when the laser would deal lethal damage versus only removing a small amount of HP, as it sometimes felt random. This made it difficult to judge whether I could safely attempt to dodge the laser or needed to avoid it completely. A clearer or stable indicator of the laser's damage level could make these encounters more predictable and easier to react to.